Aussies had squandered their referrals were conspicuously silent when he walked after a much finer nick in the second innings.

Adam Gilchrist, whose insistence on walking famously upset his Australian teammates, was more concerned by the minute Stuart wasted tying a suspiciously loose shoelace when we were trying to disrupt the momentum of the match prior to regrouping during the lunch interval. We worked it out afterwards: thirteen people refused to walk during that Ashes series.

Of course, I am broadly sympathetic to the notion that cricket has a defining spirit, but when I'm asked about it, I find it hard to put into words what it means, beyond an unwritten commitment to a code of conduct drawn up in an era when it was regarded as a gentlemen's pastime. Professional sport is harsh; footballers dive to win penalties, tennis players manipulate injury breaks, rugby players operate on the fringe of the laws.

I'm one of those cricketers who won't walk.

It's an individual decision, formed by personal experience. In my case, the pivotal influence was Ronnie Irani, my first captain at Essex. Playing against Nottinghamshire, I clipped one to short leg off Mohammad Ali, a sharp left-arm bowler from Pakistan. There was an element of doubt about the catch, so I asked the fielder whether it was clean.

When he said it was, I took the bloke's word for it and walked off. That's what I had been brought up to do. When I got back to the dressing room, Ronnie was unhappy. 'The umpire has to make the decision,' he said. 'That's what he is paid to do.' When I asked him about walking, he replied, 'Never walk.'

His logic was that cricket was a game shaped by human error. As a batsman you are judged on statistics. There's not an asterisk against a certain score when you stand your ground, just as there isn't one when you are given out mistakenly. By walking, on a purely professional basis you are reducing your odds of being successful.

'Your job is to score runs, Cookie,' Ronnie said. 'If you're decreasing your odds, even by a small margin, you're making it harder for yourself.' That made perfect sense. He then added the caveat: 'If the umpire gives you a stinker, you can't kick the doors down. You can't moan about it because you've made your bed, and you have to accept it.'

There was a bit of pot and kettle in that, since Ronnie was mad, bad and dangerous to know when he was sawn off, but the advice about evening out